living at home, I can remember getting up early on a Sunday morning and cooking a full breakfast for my mum and dad. Not because I had to but because I wanted to: cooking was something I'd always enjoyed. Don't get me wrong. I'm no Gary Rhodes or Jamie Oliver. Mum will tell you that when I was at home I'd cook the same thing every time for an evening meal. Chicken stir-fry. When Mum and Dad came up to the new house and I cooked for them in my own home for the first time, I don't think they were all that surprised at what I'd made: chicken stir-fry. Not that what we were eating was all that important. I was really proud, being able to take my parents to my own place on a Saturday night after the game. I think they were pretty proud too.

What's more, I could drive Mum and Dad home in my own car. As a boy, when I wasn't thinking about soccer, it was because I was thinking about cars. I got a Scalectrix one Christmas and drove the thing into the ground through into my teens. As well as imagining myself playing for Manchester United, I'd spent plenty of rainy afternoons thinking about the car I might turn up at Old Trafford driving one day: how about a Porsche? When I passed my test, though, that kind of fantasy car was a long way out of my range. Instead, I bought Giggsy's old club car, a red Ford Escort Mexico. Three doors, one previous owner and a full service history—that first car set me back about £6,000.

A little later, when I was going out with Deana, I needed something a bit less laddish so I bought a brand new VW Golf. I used to get slaughtered by the other United players because of the number plate M13 EKS—which, with the letters bunched up, I had looking like M BECKS. Most of the lads have probably forgotten that. The one they never left me alone about was my first sponsored club car. At the time, United had a deal with Honda to supply the young players with a new Prelude once they'd played twenty first-team games. Gary and Phil and the rest all got theirs before I did, having been involved with the senior squad more often over the previous couple of seasons. By the time I was ready to pickup mine, I'd worked out exactly what I wanted to do.

I chose one in a very dark grey. Then I paid extra to have them fit a leather interior, a new CD player and big alloy wheels. That was money I didn't really have to throw around at the time and—because the cars would go back to Honda, eventually—it was money that I was never going to see again either. Of course, my new Prelude looked completely different than everyone else's. And I loved it because it was just how I wanted it. We'd often take turns to give each other lifts into training. That particular model was pretty